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The Tenderizing Effect of Godliness

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The Tenderizing Effect of Godliness

The woman Folly is loud; she is undisciplined and without knowledge. (Proverbs 9:13)

She [the adulteress] is loud and defiant, her feet never stay at home. (Proverbs 7:11)

A wicked man puts up a bold front, but an upright man gives thought to his ways. (Proverbs 21:29)

The guy who sat at the table with me was a giant of a man, and his looks were, well, scary. Tattooed and body-pierced, the guy who went by the nickname Tiger had all the marks of a hard, high-mileage human being. He had been head of the Hells Angels motorcycle gang in Southern California; and he told of his life in drug dealing, perverse sex, compassionless crimes, intimidation, torture, killing, and hard time in the slammer. But now he was different. There was a softness in his speech and demeanor, a tenderness in his heart. He had met Jesus, surrendered to Him, and the Jesus in him was showing through.

Funny how that happens as we grow in our relationship with God. We shed the brash, insensitive, everything-be-damned attitude that is the hallmark of the wicked...however well they try to disguise it. When it serves their purposes, the wicked can put on a smooth-talk veneer—as in the adulteress whose speech “drips like honey” (5:3). But the hardness and brashness are still there under the surface.

Principle: Be wary of the person with brash, edgy speech. That sharpness may well have been honed by the grindstone of sin.

A major strategy of evil people is intimidation. Intimidating the weak or the righteous is considered a way to gain power and control. Incredibly, this strategy is so effective that professional seminars are offered in “assertiveness training.” Often “assertiveness” can be read as arrogant, blustery, bravado designed to take advantage of others. One need not be “assertive” to be a strong leader. Think coaches Tom Landry of the Dallas Cowboys or Tony Dungy of the Indianapolis Colts.

Moses himself was described as the “meekest [or humblest] man on earth” (Numbers 12:1-15). Yet he had sufficient chutzpah to lead three million grumbly Jews for forty years.

The wicked have to rely on bluster because they lack spiritual authority. A godly person with spiritual authority will control every situation out of a wellspring of security based on a relationship with God. In Jesus’ worst hour of torture, he was secure and “as a sheep before her shearers is silent” (Isaiah 53:7).

Principle: The righteous person speaks quietly with an authority infused with power from God. The arrogant intimidation of the wicked cannot shake it.

I once heard an impetuous, impulsive, unthinking person described as “He’s ‘ready-fire-aim.’” Acting before thinking, moving before establishing direction, and “giving no thought to his ways” are a mark of the sin-filled person. I believe that one of the deadly effects of refusing the enlightenment of God in one’s life is that it short-circuits the “consequence module” in the brain. The fool cannot see the disaster his evil will cause. Proverbs reserves the word “fool” for this person.

The righteous and God-fearing are careful to listen to His Word, weigh carefully and prayerfully the consequences of their words and actions, and seek wise counsel from Spirit-filled people. Their hearts are sensitive toward God and others.

Principle: The righteous person seeks God’s plan for words and action, and implements His plan in grace and patience. The “bold and the beautiful” without God don’t need His guidance; their own godlike status, they believe, will assure their success.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]

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